The Seven Deadly Sins

By Yusef Komunyakaa

INTRODUCTION

The Seven Deadly Sins, when mentioned, conjure up ancient tales of dark deeds and dark characters, like Faustus and Mephistopheles. Dr. Faustus supposedly sold his soul to the devil, the evil Mephistopheles and, in so doing, made himself prey to all types of corruption and degradation.

In his descent into wickedness, the ruined Faustus committed all of these deadly sins: pride, envy, gluttony, lust, anger, avarice, and sloth. These sins were considered deadly because they led Faustus, or any man or woman who would commit them onto a path from which there was no return.

One at a time, Yusef Komunyakaa takes a somewhat unique poetically approach to The Seven Deadly Sins.

Pride

Crowned with a feathered helmet,

Not for disguise or courtship

Dance, he looks like something

Birthed by swallowing its tail,

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Woven from a selfish design

& guesswork. As if masked

With a see-through caul

From breast to hipbone,

His cold breath silvers

Panes of his hilltop house

Into a double reflection.

Silhouetted almost into a woman,

He can beg forgiveness now

As he leans against a window

Overlooking Narcissus's pond

Choked with a memory of lilies.

Envy

Icarus imitated the golden plover,

Drawn toward a blue folly

Above, looping through echoes

Of a boy's prankish laughter,

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Through an airy labyrinth
Of conjecture. A lifetime
Ahead of Daedalus, with noon sun
In his eyes, he outflew the bird's

Equilibrium, wondering how this
Small creature of doubt braved
The briny trade winds. Surely,
In a fanfare of uneclipsed wings

Driven by dash & breathless style,
He could outdo the plover's soars
& dares. But he couldn't stop
Counting feathers against salty sky.

Gluttony

In a country of splendor & high
Ritual, in a fat land of zeros,
Sits a man with string & bone
For stylus, hunched over his easel,

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Captured by perfection.
But also afflictions live behind
Electric fences, among hedges
& a whirlwind of roses, down

To where he sits beside a gully
Pooling desires. He squints
Till the mechanical horizon is one
Shadowplay against bruised sky,

Till the smoky perfume limps
Into undergrowth. He balls up
Another sheet in unblessed fingers, always
Ready to draw the thing that is all mouth.

Lust

If only he could touch her,
Her name like an old wish
In the stopped weather of salt
On a snail. He longs to be

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Words, juicy as passionfruit
On her tongue. He'd do anything,
Would dance three days & nights
To make the most terrible gods

Rise out of ashes of the yew,
To step from the naked
Fray, to be as tender
As meat imagined off

The bluegill's pearlish
Bones. He longs to be
An orange, to feel fingernails
Run a seam through him.

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Anger

We can cut out Nemesis's tongue
By omission or simple analysis.
Doesn't this sin have to marry
Another, like a wishbone

Worked into meat, to grow
Deadly? Snared within
The blood's quick night,
Our old gods made of sex

& wit, of nitrate & titanium,
Hurl midnight thunderbolts
& lightning. Are we here
Because they must question

Every death in an alley,
Every meltdown? We know
We wouldn't be much, if thorns
Didn't drive light into wet blooms.

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Avarice

At six, she chewed off
The seven porcelain buttons
From her sister's christening gown
& hid them in a Prince Albert can

On a sill crisscrossing the house
In the spidery crawlspace.
She'd weigh a peach in her hands
Till it rotted. At sixteen,

She gazed at her little brother's
Junebugs pinned to a sheet of cork,
Assaying their glimmer, till she
Buried them beneath a fig tree's wide,

Green skirt. Now, twenty-six,
Locked in the beauty of her bones,
She counts eight engagement rings
At least twelve times each day.

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Sloth (after all it is an animal too!)

If you're one of seven
Downfalls, up in your kingdom
Of mulberry leaves, there are men
Betting you aren't worth a bullet,

That your skin won't tan into a good
Wallet. As if drugged in the womb
& limboed in a honeyed languor,
By the time you open your eyes

A thousand species have lived
& died. Born on a Sunday
Morning, with old-world algae
In your long hair, a goodness

Disguised your two-toed claws
Bright as flensing knives. In this
Upside-down haven, you're reincarnated
As a fallen angel trying to go home.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Yusef Komunyakaa
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